

avoidance. The problem with such advice is twofold. First, it misunderstands the purpose of money. Second, it fundamentally misses out on the best way to make intelligent financial decisions.

Money is misunderstood by many. The problem is people and how they behave around money. Money is not the root of all evil; the Bible references “the pursuit of money.” Money is merely a tool, a medium of exchange.

At its most basic level, money allows sustenance and security: Food, housing, clothes, medical care, and transportation. Get a little more of it, and you can pay for your kids’ education and take a nice vacation now and again. Freedom from worry is a nice benefit of having enough to cover the above. If you’re fortunate enough to have more than enough, you have options: Entertainment, hobbies, travel, philanthropy, or whatever catches your fancy.

This brings us back to the boat mentioned above.⁴⁴³ Assuming you have enough cash and/or credit, using some of it to buy a boat is simply an option, one that should be considered intelligently.

Let’s start with the costs. There is the purchase price, which my experience as a boater teaches is the cheapest part of boating. Where will you keep it—at a marina slip (most expensive but most convenient), a mooring (cheaper but less convenient), or a trailer (cheapest but least convenient)? You might own a dock, but that means you spent a lot of money on related real estate. Maintenance and repairs are not cheap, especially if you are out in saltwater (as opposed to freshwater lakes and rivers). There are issues of winter storage if you live in the north, and then prep for boating season. Fuel and insurance are costs, as are snacks and beer.

These are all easily calculable by anyone with a spreadsheet or even a pencil and paper. You should be able to determine what a boat will cost you; assuming you have a household budget (what do you mean you don’t?!), then you should also know how much boat you can afford.

How much are you going to use it? What friends and family will